

outside debris and should be vacuumed before you turn on the unit at the beginning of every season.

Your water heater will typically last eight to fifteen years. If your heater falls into this time frame when you buy the house, consider installing a water alarm near the base of the unit. The water heater fails from the inside out, and failure can start as a small leak. A water alarm can help you keep tabs on this.

If something ever goes horribly wrong and you find a high-dollar issue, always check to see whether your insurance policy covers that particular problem. While it doesn't normally cover poor home maintenance or neglect on your part, it might cover something out of your control—like damage caused by natural disasters or theft and vandalism. This varies from policy to policy, but it never hurts to check before doling out any cash.

Last but not least, anything from the inspection report that was not fixed by the seller should go on your to-do list. Keeping your home in good repair makes selling it much easier down the road. Years from now, you don't want those same issues popping up on the *next* buyer's inspection report.

YOUR STUPID QUESTIONS, ANSWERED

Time for a classic philosophical question featured in many young classrooms: *Is there such a thing as a stupid question?* Your teacher's polite answer has always been and will always be "Of course not," and our answer is the same. If you've never bought a house before, even the smallest question can leave you wringing your hands for days—and Google doesn't always have the answers you need.

However, the stupidity of a question is based mainly on the sheer embarrassment felt while asking it. Have you ever had to pronounce "Worcestershire sauce" in front of someone from Massachusetts? Yeah, it's the same feeling as when you ask your lender if your new house comes with lightbulbs.

Don't worry, though—here's a long (and private) list of those painful new-homeowner questions you're too afraid to ask anyone else. And, of course, you should never be afraid to ask your agent or lender for clarification. They've heard it all before.